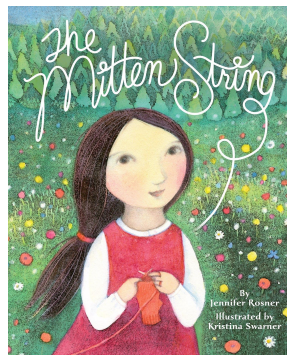




The Mitten String Collaborative Program with Chabad & PJ Library



The Mitten String

Written by Jennifer Rosner

Illustrated by Kristina Swarner

Goals:

Create a collaborative children's program highlighting Inclusion with PJ Library and Chabad

Target Audience:

Recommended for Children Ages 3-10

Time:

Approximately 1 hour

Medium:

Facilitated program created for virtual programming and can easily be adapted for in-person programs.

Note to Facilitator:

- This collaborative program idea (not the details) has been shared with PJ Libraries throughout the USA in which they are encouraged to reach out to their local Chabad House to collaborate. You are welcome to reach out directly to your local PJ Library rep to collaborate on this program, or contact the RCII team at 701-404-7244(RCII) or info@shabbattogether.com and we can connect you with your local PJ Library rep.
- Below are different ideas for activities that can be facilitated with groups both virtually and in person. Please read the whole program to decide which activities will work best for your community.

- Once you have chosen your activities for your program, [Click here to create an @Home supply list](#) to share with your families in advance if doing a virtual program.
- Use these Canva links to [edit your designed Flyer](#) and [Social Media post](#) to share your program with your community.

Synopsis

Ruthie Tober and her family are traveling home from selling wool and knitted mittens at the market when they meet Bayla and her baby, Aaron. Ruthie's family invites Bayla, who is deaf, and Aaron to stay with them. Ruthie wonders how Bayla knows if Aaron wakes up at night. Bayla has a way for Aaron to communicate with her. They each hold the end of a blue string and Aaron tugs on it to wake his mother. When Ruthie sees that Aaron woke up because his hands were cold, and she comes up with a way to help—she knits mittens for Bayla and Aaron and adds a mitten string to connect them in the night. Bayla also has something for Ruthie: she teaches her the sign for “mittens” and how to find the plant that will dye the wool a bright blue.

Why We Chose The Mitten String

The Mitten String is a wonderful tale about seeing each person as a unique and wonderful creation. It shows respect for others and teaches us that everyone has unique skills and abilities to contribute to our world. This book offers the strong lesson that we are ALL better when we create an inclusive community and learn from everyone. The strings on the mittens—that connect parent to child and that later help each child keep track of their mittens is a symbol of how we all “keep track” of each other so that no one is lost to the Jewish community. “Kol Yisrael Arevim Zeh La Zeh” - “All Israel are Responsible for One Another.”

Getting Started

The Community activities for The Mitten String are created for virtual programming and can easily be adapted for in-person programs.

- Close caption your Zoom programs either with a third-party service such as [rev.com](#) or have someone from your organization type the captions. Google Meet can also be used instead of Zoom and has automatic Closed Captioning available for free.
- Contact your local PJ Library Representative to collaborate on The Mitten String activities. Find your [local PJ Library](#).
- Find your [local Chabad HERE](#) to collaborate on this program.
- The Mitten String is available as a [Kindle ebook](#) so you can screen share as it's being read. It's also available in other [formats](#).

Virtual program Activity Ideas:

- Offer a **virtual community reading** of The Mitten String on Zoom. The ebook format is perfect for screen sharing.
- **Read The Mitten String as a play:**
 - Choose several people to be the Narrator. Ruthie and her mother have speaking parts. Ask the “actors” to have props to show on camera:
 - Narrators: A hat or a head scarf.
 - Ruthie: a ball of yarn and a pair of knitting needles, and one pair of mittens. (Optional stuffed cat).
 - Bayla: a small chalkboard with the names “Bayla” and “Aaron” written on it, a length of any shade of blue yarn, and a pair of mittens.
 - Ruthie’s Mother: a ball of yarn and a pair of knitting needles.
 - Baby Aaron: a length of any shade of blue yarn and a pair of mittens.
- **Teach how to sign:**
 - Teach how to sign the words in the Sign Language Glossary at the end of the book: Mitten, Yarn, Knit, Wool, and Sheep.
- **Virtual Bedtime Story Event:**
 - Ask participants to cozy up with a cup of hot chocolate and marshmallows while you read The Mitten String using an ebook and screen share.
 - Ask children and their parents what they learned from The Mitten String. Unmute so they can comment. You might also ask them what they can do to help someone else.
 - Items needed at home for program:
 - Hot chocolate, marshmallows and pjs
- **ASL interpreter:**
 - Invite an **ASL interpreter** to sign The Mitten String while you are reading it.
 - The National Association of State Agencies for the Deaf and Hard of Hearing (NASADHH) has links to individual state agencies. <http://nasadhh.org/usa-roster/>
- **No two fingerprints are the same:**
 - Make fingerprint designs in play dough. Encourage the children to notice the uniqueness of each print.
 - Items needed at home for program:
 - Play dough or stamp pad

Virtual Program - Jewish Values Activities:

Below are two Jewish values in the book with some food for thought and activities.

- ❖ **Value 1: V'ahavta l'rayacha kamocho** (Vayikra 19:18). We are taught “you shall love your neighbor as yourself.”
 - In *The Mitten String*, Ruthie sees that baby Aaron awakens at night because his hands are cold. She knows that she can show her love for him by making something he needs—a pair of hand knit mittens to ease his discomfort. Let’s say

that Ruthie wakes up in the middle of the night to get a drink of water because she's thirsty. When she checks on Aaron, Ruthie sees that Aaron's hands are cold.

- Should she give him some water? That's what she needed. But Ruthie saw that Aaron's hands were cold and he needed mittens to keep them warm. She makes him a pair of warm mittens because this is what Aaron needs.
- This is what is meant by loving your neighbor as yourself—to respond to what *your neighbor needs* rather than giving them something *you need*.

- **Value 1 Activities:**

- Draw pictures based on this value and your own version of when Ruthie discovered that Aaron was awake because he was cold, or Ruthie giving Aaron his new mittens.
 - Items needed at home for program:
 - Paper
 - Crayons/markers
- Make play dough mitten shapes and decorate them with different colors of play dough, buttons, and yarn.
 - Items needed at home for program:
 - Play dough
 - Buttons, yarn

❖ **Value 2: Kol Adam meyuchad. Each person is unique.**

- *The Mitten String* teaches that each of us has something that is uniquely ours, our superpowers. One of Ruthie's superpowers is knitting and she makes mittens to keep others nice and warm. Bayla, who is deaf, has problem-solving superpowers. She creates a clever way for her baby to communicate with her in the night and she uses her superpowers to communicate and share her talents with those around her.

- **Value 2 Activities:**

- What is your superpower? How can your superpower help others around you?
- Draw a picture of yourself using your superpower to help someone.
 - Items needed at home for program:
 - Paper
 - Crayons/markers
- Discuss ways each person can help your community—a food drive for the local food shelf, give mittens and gloves to a homeless shelter, collect children's books for a shelter or a preschool and brainstorm new ideas.